



Rs 78_{cr}

**total cost of
the movie**

magic of mint and coin), the 57-year-old who started his career as a villain in K. Balachandar's *Apoorva Ragangal*, 1975, has been less about the person, and more about the persona, not so much the star, as much as the style. In *Siraji*, clad in tailored suits and designer belt buckles handpicked by Manish Malhotra, the former bus conductor from Bangalore solidifies his status as a symbol—both of a vibrant film industry as well as a thriving region. The film is as much about pop politics as it is about pop cinema. To his fans, Rajnikant is more than an actor—as was evident on June 15 when cutouts of him, some 154 feet wide to signify his 154th film, were offered beer, a contemporary stand-in for the more traditional milk *abhishekam*. He is one of the few celebrities in India who is able to have a running

154

**total number
of films**

the star has acted in

conversation with people from all spheres, from an auto-driver to an IT expert, from a *paatti* (grandma) to a *kuzhandai* (child). Like Anirudh, a 38-year-old IT specialist working in New Jersey—who cancelled his trip to India on June 14 after he managed to get the first-day first-show tickets at Cine Plaza to watch *Siraji*. He says he did not mind spending \$200 for the privilege or missing out on visiting his parents in Chennai after a three-year gap. And that's when he doesn't consider himself a hardcore fan—that appellation is reserved for those thousands who belong to his 38,000-strong fan clubs.

His 100th Tamil movie has been breaking records for its ubiquity. Already, his latest movie has recorded the highest ever monotone downloads of 50,000 in a day.

Rs 96_{cr}

**is the amount
paid by
distributors**

**STYLE STATEMENT: Rajnikant
returns with *Sivaji*, after two years**